

Right A gateway through the walls of the Forbidden City frames the Hall of Supreme Harmony, the ceremonial center of imperial power

Below Shredded meat from the roasted duck is wrapped in a wheat-flour pancake with green onion and cucumber



A Day in Beijing

Beijing's recent modernization hasn't quite managed to obliterate over 700 years of history – and the famous Great Wall is just an hour or so from the center of the city.

MORNING Catch a van to the **Great Wall** at Mutianyu and spend a couple of hours walking between watchtowers along this incredible structure, then head back to Beijing for a late lunch. Alternatively, start the day at the **Forbidden City**, the mighty imperial palace complex from which generations of emperors ruled China.

AFTERNOON Walk off lunch at the **Temple of Heaven Park**, admiring the splendid exterior of the temple itself, before heading to the *hutongs* for a stroll through the streets of old Beijing.

EVENING Grab a snack at **Dong'anmen Night Market** – you might want to avoid the scorpion kebabs – then decide whether to rub elbows with locals at one of the **Sanlitun** district's many bars, or settle in for a striking, if incomprehensible, performance of **Peking Opera**.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Beijing is connected to China and the rest of the world by **air** and **rail**. Use a combination of **metro train**, **bus**, and **taxi** to negotiate the city's vast, gridlike street plan.

WHERE TO STAY

Beijing Downtown Backpackers (inexpensive) has clean, central rooms. +86 10 8400 2429
Bamboo Garden Hotel (moderate), down an old *hutong* alley, is full of character with a splendid landscaped garden. www.bbgh.com.cn

Haoyuan (moderate) is a traditionally furnished courtyard house. www.haoyuanhotel.com

FURTHER INFORMATION

Go to www.cityweekend.com.cn/beijing for English-language news and listings.

